Reporting an experiment and its findings

Goal: To write a short report on a simple experiment with the standard sections (aim, materials, procedure, results, conclusion), using the passive voice, sequencers and cause-and-result connectors.

The idea in two lines: An experiment report answers four questions: what we wanted to find out, what we did, what we observed, and what it means. The style is impersonal: the passive voice focuses on the actions and findings, not on the people.

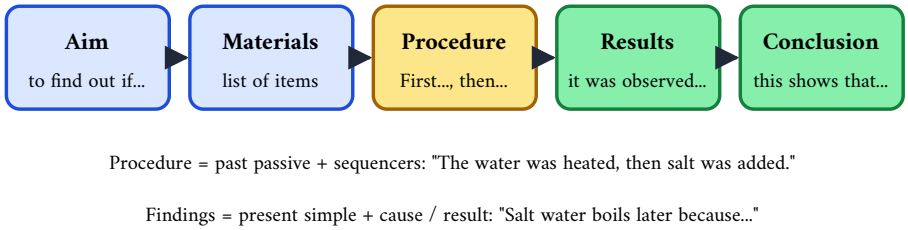


Figure 1: The five sections of an experiment report and the language used in each.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Aim:** one sentence with "to + verb": The aim of this experiment was to find out whether salt changes the boiling point of water.
2. **Materials:** a simple list of the equipment and substances used (a beaker, a thermometer, water, salt).
3. **Procedure:** the steps in order, in the **past simple passive** with sequencers: First, 200 ml of water was poured into a beaker. Then it was heated...
4. **Results:** what was observed or measured, often with numbers: It was noticed that... / The temperature rose to...
5. **Conclusion / findings:** what the results prove, in the present simple with cause and result connectors: The results show that... ; therefore, ...

6. **Impersonal style:** avoid "I" and "we"; prefer the passive. Useful **reporting verbs:** show, reveal, indicate, prove, confirm.

🟢 Examples

1. Write the procedure from these notes: pour water / add 2 spoons of salt / heat / note the temperature. **Answer:** First, water was poured into a beaker. Then, 2 spoons of salt were added. After that, the mixture was heated. Finally, the boiling temperature was noted. **Explanation:** past passive + a different sequencer for each step.
2. Write a conclusion for: pure water boiled at 100°C; salt water boiled at 101°C. **Answer:** The results show that salt water boils at a higher temperature than pure water. Therefore, salt raises the boiling point of water. **Explanation:** reporting verb + present simple + result connector.
3. Make this sentence impersonal: We saw that the ice melted faster in the sun. **Answer:** It was observed that the ice melted faster in the sun.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Writing the procedure in the imperative (Pour the water...) instead of the past passive.
- Using "I" and "we" throughout the report instead of the impersonal style.
- Mixing results (what was seen) with the conclusion (what it means).
- Forgetting sequencers, so the steps have no clear order.

🟡 Quick review

- Aim → Materials → Procedure → Results → Conclusion.
- Procedure: past passive + first / then / after that / finally.
- Results: it was observed / noticed that...
- Conclusion: the results show that... + therefore / so.
- No "I / we": keep it impersonal.